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(Clockwise from left) A still from *Be Kucheye Khoshbakht*; Turkish actress Melisa Sözen in *Roya*; and filmmakers Sreemoyee Singh; and Mahnaz Mohammadi. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT, BERLINALE, PAK FILM, AND ABHISHEK BHATTACHARYYA)



'Resistance is not opposing a force, but refusing to disappear'

Mahnaz Mohammadi

Mohammadi made news in India in 2022 during the International Film Festival of Kerala. She was to receive the Spirit of Cinema Award the same year Hungarian director Béla Tarr was given the Lifetime Achievement Award. She was looking forward to meeting Tarr, but her visa was denied. Mohammadi sent a lock of her hair in her stead. "Cut hair is the symbol of the tragedy that we face every day and every moment," she had said in interviews then.

Weeks before the U.S.-Israeli assassination of Khamenei, when I meet her at the 76th Berlinale, at the world premiere of her sophomore feature *Roya*, she allows me to record her on camera – because she loves Indians. An Indian friend had once gifted her a clock, the time on which she didn't change. Now, that frozen time acts like a good memory. For Mohammadi, life has been a series of fragments that flits between memory and forgetting, the conscious and unconscious, dream and reality, past and present.

That is also how the non-linear *Roya* is structured. Shot clandestinely, and featuring

Turkish actress Melisa Sözen (*Winter Sleep*, 2014), it reveals how isolation can reshape perception, identity, and the fragile possibility of resistance. *Roya*, which in Persian means dream, is the story of an Iranian teacher who is imprisoned in Tehran's Evin Prison for her political beliefs and is faced with a choice: to either make a forced televised confession or remain confined to her 3 sq.m. cell. The film draws from Mohammadi's own time in prison.

'When I becomes we'

Her active involvement in 'Campaign for Equality' in 2006, to demand changes to discriminatory laws against Iranian women, put her in the line of fire. The Islamic Regime arrested her multiple times: in 2007, 2009 (when she wrote an open letter during post-election unrest), 2011, and in 2014 (when she spent five years in Evin Prison). She has also been banned by Iran from making films – after her debut feature *Son-Mother* (2019) – because of her long history of activism and socially critical filmmaking.

"I'm a woman, I'm a filmmaker, I'm guilty. But now it's not 'I', it's

HER LENS ON IRAN

Two filmmakers — an Iranian and an Indian — reflect on *jin, jiyan, azadi* (woman, life, freedom) in the war-torn country through their cinema

Tanushree Ghosh

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On March 1, a day after news broke about Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei's assassination, New York-based exiled Iranian-American journalist, activist and author Masih Alinejad, 49, was one of the loudest jubilant voices. She posted an emotional video on X: "Every morning, I wake up reading that my people are being killed by Ali Khamenei. But this is the first morning in my life that I get the good news. I wanna run and shout out of joy Ali Khamenei is dead! Free Iran!" The war escalated on February 28 with U.S.-Israel airstrikes on Iran to counter Tehran's nuclear influence. The conflict follows years of tension.

Alinejad left Iran in 2009 to escape imprisonment. Years later, the image of her with loose black hair became the face of her 2014 online campaign, 'My Stealthy Freedom', inspiring Iranian women to rail against compulsory *hijab*. That led to the campaign 'White Wednesdays', where women dressed in white, took to the streets, taking off their headscarves, in the face of abuse or arrest. "My principle is simple, I am for women's right to choose," she told me in 2018, around the release of her memoir, *The Wind in My Hair: My Fight for Freedom in Modern Iran* (Hachette), her first book in English.

Art, no matter the medium (books, music, cinema), often is political. Alinejad's words, hair, and initiatives, for instance, also

spawned #GirlsofRevolutionStreet protest and #MyCameralMyWeapon campaign, where women filmed and posted online their altercations with the morality police. So, this year, at the 76th Berlinale, when international jury president Wim Wenders said cinema "is the counterweight of politics... we have to do the work of people, not the work of politicians" in response to Gaza, it made headlines.

Political frame

For Iranian cinema, politics has always been its subtext. We speak to two filmmakers who reflect on *jin, jiyan, azadi* (woman, life, freedom) in Iran through their cinema. Iranian filmmaker Mahnaz Mohammadi, 51, lives and films there, while Indian documentary filmmaker Sreemoyee Singh, 36, went to Iran to study Persian and make a film. Both their films premiered at the Berlinale — Mohammadi's *Roya* in 2026, and Singh's *Be Kucheye Khoshbakht* (*And, Towards Happy Alleys*) in 2023, in the Panorama segment.

"Everything is political; the fact that we are breathing and living in our relationship to society, that itself is political," says Singh. Mohammadi, on the other hand, is clear she is *not* making political films. "But the situation that the people are living in, I can't ignore it. In Iran, the act of going out on the street after 6 p.m. has become activism, because everywhere so many people are being arrested, killed. How can I divide it between this and that? I don't want to make a film about that, but I want to make a film about what happens after those politics suppress the people."

A geopolitical mess

"A lot of Iranians are celebrating on the streets, happy and relieved about Khamenei's death because, since 1979, this regime has been the reason for thousands of Iranians being executed, spending their lives in prison, and more," says filmmaker Sreemoyee Singh. But, at the same time, she shares that her friends in Iran feel stuck in this geopolitical mess. "They've told me that 'we are stuck between three evil forces: the IRGC [Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps], which has ruined our lives; Israel, which is on a genocidal spree; and the U.S., which is complicit in all these war crimes. Between them, one has died now. But the fact is that Tehran is still being bombed and destroyed. Israel cannot bring liberation to Iran because it doesn't care about human life or dignity."

'we', says Mohammadi. Her deeply humanistic films focus on lived experiences under repression, giving voice to those silenced by the system. "Resistance is not opposing a force, but refusing to disappear," she says. "In childhood, I used to think, 'Where is hope? Maybe when I'm grown-up, I will go and get that hope'. But through life I've learnt it is not like that; it is the way of your living and practising. With cinema, you're making hope."

Days before the bombings, Mohammadi spoke of the western world's hypocrisy and silence of the Leftists on Iran. "So many countries didn't see our pain. We just became part of the Islamic Republic's property. In 2009, I wrote [about] this, but who listened? Nobody. People inside Iran are fighting for survival. And, still I have hope," she says. "After the [January] massacre [that killed around 30,000 Iranians], I think the people got more motivation for change. What I heard is that they didn't believe the Islamic Republic could see the Persian New Year. Just imagine how hopeful they were – because for them, the regime's killing of their children would end. It will be over." In retrospect, her words sound prophetic.



People are hurt, angry, shocked and restless. A lot of them are against this attack. We have seen what America's attack on Iraq and Afghanistan did. The people of Iran know that these attacks will not bring happier days

MOHAMMADREZA AZADI
Iranian filmmaker

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Scan the QR code to watch Mahnaz Mohammadi in conversation on magazine.thehindu.com



ARITHMETIC OF LOSS

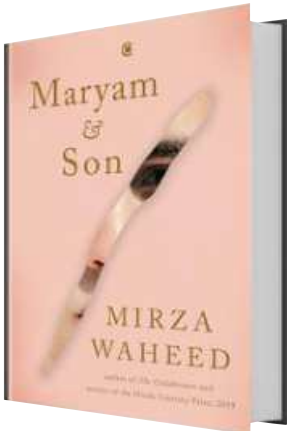
Mirza Waheed examines the disappearance of a young man within the framework of Muslim-immigrant life in suburban London

Attaul Munim Zahid

Last year, when the spectre of war between India and Pakistan seemed to crystallise, my mother compelled me to return from Delhi on the final flight to Kashmir before they were suspended. Her logic was precise in its irrationality. I would be safer with her, even though Kashmir stood closer to the line of fire. For her, it seemed to me, safety was not geography but proximity: the fact of having her son within reach. Mirza Waheed's *Maryam & Son* begins with the ostensible collapse of that logic, when a mother discovers that proximity is no longer hers to command.

Maryam Ali, a widow, who lives in Walthamstow, London, wakes up one morning to find Dilawar, her only son, missing from his bedroom. At first, Maryam and her sisters, Zarrine and Saffina, assume he has gone away briefly, but their anxiety deepens when he does not return, and they go to the police.

Intelligence officers from the 'Joint Section' become involved, bringing into Maryam's life Julian Chapman, a counter-extremism liaison officer, whose professional detachment gradually gives way to a complicated intimacy. The unit



Maryam & Son
Mirza Waheed
Context
₹699

suspects that Dil may have travelled to Iraq and could be the masked IS (Islamic State) recruit they nickname the 'Swordsman', identified through their 72% algorithmic match from a video posted online.

The way *Maryam & Son* opens, without spectacle or rupture, establishes the novel's psychological gravity. Dil's disappearance does not register immediately as catastrophe. Maryam refuses to let her situation erupt outward, especially towards her sisters. The disappearance is not an explosion but an inward collapse as Maryam protects them from her suffering even as they stand ready to share it. Their bond is so tender that the novel could just as easily have been called *Maryam & Sisters*.

Shape of grief

One of the novel's most unsettling insights is how the intelligence apparatus entangles Maryam in the logic of suspicion. She, a British-Indian Muslim whose faith and identity become a part of the investigation, is neither accused nor absolved but made to inhabit the space of guilt by association. The officers who enter her life operate within an impersonal regime bereft of 'feelings and ethics', while the media compounds this abstraction by circulating her image in a headscarf she does not ordinarily wear, reframing her to fit a familiar narrative of Muslim culpability.

This estrangement seeps into her everyday life, in graffitis branding her a 'Paki traitor' or a kindergartener calling her 'ISIS mum'. Waheed, parallely, resists flattening, preserving the

dignity of Maryam's lived reality where ordinary kindness, embodied by figures like her neighbour Tony, persists alongside bigotry.

Like Shahnaz Bashir's 2014 novel *Half Mother*, which follows a woman waiting for her disappeared son, *Maryam & Son* inhabits the emotional afterlife of loss. But where Bashir situates absence within the visible machinery of enforced disappearance in Kashmir, Waheed examines its ambiguous form within Muslim-immigrant life in suburban London. *Maryam & Son* does its finest work in illuminating the uncertain condition of a mother forced to live with the looming awareness of who her son might have become. Instead of following Dil's potentially sensational trajectory, Waheed compels a reader to remain with Maryam, restoring attention to her 'ordinary' life.

Sustaining the composure of its opening, *Maryam & Son* captures the slow accommodation of grief without ever dramatising it. Maryam beats Dil's clothes in frustration, reproaches her dead husband for leaving her to endure alone, indulges in self-blame, and yet continues to walk, to shop, to inhabit her days with a fragile, stubborn hope. It reminded me of Joan Didion's beautiful book *The Year of Magical Thinking*. Didion wrote of grief as a condition that alters perception itself, that makes someone's absence feel provisional, that "grief turns out to be a place none of us know until we reach it".

Waheed arrives at the same emotional truth when Maryam, alone with Dil's photograph, reflects that grief "is not a state of mind, it's not something you do or don't, nor something that fades away with time, but that it's a living, breathing thing that resides within you, somewhere behind your eyelids. You close your eyes and you feel the shadow of the lost one flit across. It's best to let it live there and make peace with it. Carry it with you."

Different truths

Quite unanticipated, Waheed's rendering of the 'Joint Section' and its counterparts is executed with remarkable technical precision. It lends the novel a tensive, thriller-like atmosphere, invoking the propulsive world of Forsyth while remaining grounded in the quiet social tumult characteristic of Coetzee. Yet, the transitions never feel jarring.

Waheed captures a parent's bewilderment when forced to inhabit two incompatible truths: Maryam must defend her son against the world's accusation even as she quietly interrogates her own memories for signs she may have missed.

Motherhood, after all, can't be only contingent on proximity. Love does not end when presence ends and is neither revoked by distance nor ideology. As the algorithmic probability of Dil being the 'Swordsman' rises from 72% to 78%, Maryam confronts the arithmetic of her loss: "I don't know how to look for the 22 per cent of him that isn't a terrorist."

The reviewer is a writer and journalist with experience in publishing.

INTERNATIONAL BOOKER PRIZE-LONGLISTED

Myths of blood and brotherhood

In her prison novella, Brazilian writer Ana Paula Maia refuses to validate men's violence, offering a tight narrative of human suffering

Vasudevan Mukunth
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Brazilian writer Ana Paula Maia's *On Earth As It Is Beneath*, envisioned for English readers by Canadian author and translator Padma Viswanathan, is a taut horror. It tells the story of a brutal prison warden's descent into madness as he transforms his penal colony into a hunting ground and treats the few remaining inmates like livestock.

As food dwindles and the sweltering heat rises, the desperate prisoners must rely on their primal instincts to survive. Thus, Maia explores the terrifying reality that emerges when the boundary between man and beast melts. The slim novella is on this year's longlist for the International Booker Prize.

The colony is built atop a former plantation where enslaved people were historically tortured and murdered, with later attempts at ordinary life repeatedly collapsing into sickness, fire, disappearance, and abandonment. Maia paints a picture of a landscape literally saturated with atrocities, where every attempt to dig into the earth yields human remains, leading to the gut-wrenching realisation that the colony's brutality is only the latest iteration of Brazil's foundational violence.

A ledger of actions

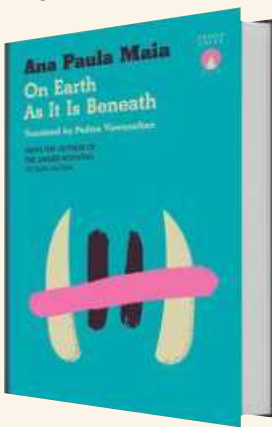
The novel, published in the original Portuguese in 2017, is entirely populated by men, set in an isolated, hermetically sealed pressure cooker of violence. Yet, the architects of this narrative are women. The text is guided by Maia's female authorial gaze that strips the hyper-masculine Colony of its traditional patriarchal glamour. There is no idealised brotherhood, no glorious final stand. Instead, Maia's autopsy, rendered with surgical precision by Viswanathan's translation, reveals a pathetic ouroboros.

Bronco Gil comes of age when he learns to gut wild boars without vomiting. Melquiades inherits his violent masculinity from his policeman father, a man who read the *Bible* but killed criminals with the same indifference he applied to hunting. Left entirely to their own devices, these men build and inhabit a hellscape. Male authors writing about male prisons or violent outlaws often romanticise the 'tough guy', but Maia refuses to validate the violence and Viswanathan preserves the detachment.

On Earth's human suffering comes up in the tight, present-tense narrative and the

vocabulary of the slaughterhouse. A dying dog is buried with a hoe in one scene while dead human prisoners are dragged on tarps encrusted with blood and dumped into rocky, shallow graves in the next. The translator's selection of Anglo-Saxon verbs creates a matter-of-fact language to describe profound atrocities.

Much of the story is a ledger of actions: bury the dog, peel the potatoes, butcher the boar, salt the hide, mend the sock, hang the trophy, polish the boots, remove the tag, start the stopwatch, fire the rifle. Viswanathan



On Earth As It Is Beneath
Ana Paula Maia, trs Padma Viswanathan
Charco Press
₹1,265

captures this machine-gun rhythm perfectly, allowing the syntax to mimic the repetitive labour of survival. The narration lingers on craft and process, such as the careful steps of taxidermy and curing a hide, down to salt and potassium alum, and waiting two months for ants to strip a skull. The place is itself invasively material, with its sweat, rot, tools, dirt, meats, bones, and odours forcing us, alongside the inmates, to face the unacceptable.

Justifying the atrocity

On Earth is reminiscent of what the Italian philosopher Giorgio Agamben called 'bare life'.

Across *Homo Sacer* and *The Open*, Agamben argued politics in modernity increasingly works by creating and maintaining a split within the human: a speaking and rights-bearing figure on one side and an exposed biological organism on the other. And sovereign power makes its presence felt by reducing the former to the latter. The ultimate figure of this is the *homo sacer* – a person stripped of all legal rights and who can be killed by anyone without consequence yet who cannot be used in a religious sacrifice because their life has lost all value.

In the penal colony, law is suspended and Melquiades wields absolute power over life and death. When he hunts J with a rifle and a stopwatch, he is slaughtering biological material.

It's impossible in the end to not recognise the sprawling architecture of our own state of exception. The pandemic laid bare the state as it presumed to roll out untested drugs and therapies, treating the population as bodies available to serve its political ends.

The same calculus is evident in today's strongmen and their foot soldiers transforming borders and cities into macrocosms of the Penal Colony. They continuously designate minorities and dissidents to subjugate, justifying the atrocity through the same hollow myths of blood and brotherhood.



GETTY IMAGES/ ISTOCK

BROWSER

My Home is Dissent

Pooja Ugrani
Poetrywala
₹399
An architect and teacher, Ugrani draws on her experiences of love, labour, and loss shaping poems that emerge from memory, work, and motherhood. Her verses have been included in compilations such as *The Kali Project* anthology and the *Yearbook of Indian Poetry 2022*.



Hot Butter Cuttlefish

Ashok Ferrey
Penguin Random House
₹499
A dark, quirky Sri Lankan novel about love, karma, and small-town life. Ferrey's 2003 debut, *Colpetty People*, remains the country's top-selling book to date. A former TV host and builder, Ferrey is the only non-architect to have been nominated for a Geoffrey Bawa Award for Architectural Excellence.



My Dead Flowers

Buku Sarkar
HarperCollins
₹499
This collection of poems and photographs moves between the streets of Calcutta, New York and Paris. This is the second book in the Thayil Editions, curated by novelist Jeet Thayil, who aims to bring out 20 such experimental titles over five years.



Sisters in Yellow

Mieko Kawakami, trs Laurel Taylor and Hitomi Yoshio
Picador
₹750
Set in 1990s Tokyo, this is a gritty story of sacrifice and friendship. Kawakami, shortlisted for the International Booker Prize in 2022, explores the female body and questions of gender, class and ethics in her writing, which has been translated into over 40 languages.





PANKAJAM, THE ASPIRATIONAL HEROINE

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The best kind of personal histories are those that go beyond memory. A personal history that manages to be, at the same time, a record of the history of a nation in the throes of growth, of cities stretching out, of minds being coaxed to expand. That is the kind of narrative that makes for a riveting read. That is exactly what Kalpana Karunakaran's book *A Woman of No Consequence* is all about.

Karunakaran writes a family history – a feminist treatise centring around three generations of women in her family and the men and women who shaped their lives – as a history of a newly born nation seen through the eyes of women. The fault lines of a nation, a society, and a caste are exposed in the lives of the women, who are denied time and again opportunities and rights, and who still exert themselves to rise from the morass to which society has confined them. Hemmed in as they are by Brahmin orthodoxy, there is still a free spirit that rests in the women and makes them, for us, the readers, women of great consequence, inspirational, and worthy of emulation.

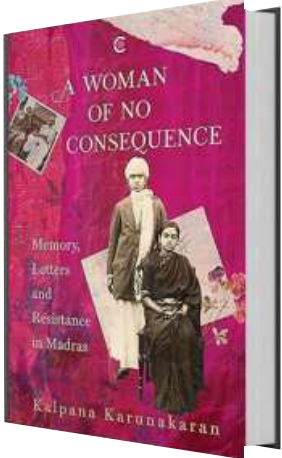
Indeed, the book describes well a group of women, but the true heroine is undoubtedly Pankajam – Karunakaran's maternal grandmother. Karunakaran's great grandmother, Subbulakshmi, and her own mother, the late communist leader Mythili Sivaraman, play important roles, as do other women, as Karunakaran steers them through the years, crafting a treatise that sees each generation of women do better than the one before them.

Suffering trails the early generations, as the privations assigned to gender identity are endured – women denied an education, agency, books, a thinking mind, and an opportunity to grow into their own selves. And yet each woman tries to ensure a better

Kalpana Karunakaran's work on her maternal grandmother is a personal history that becomes a nation's story



(Clockwise from above, right) Pankajam; with her father; with her children. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT, ISTOCK)



A Woman Of No Consequence: Memory, Letters and Resistance in Madras
Kalpana Karunakaran
Westland Books
₹599

Life: A Family Archive (on the life of her grandmother Subbulakshmi), and extensive correspondence – epistles between family members, school mates, even a British traveller and a Russian scholar of Tamil – that are all astonishingly well preserved all these years later.

Pankajam was a prolific writer, yet she was constrained as she was clear that she would not resort to washing dirty linen in public. While swearing to write the truth, she declares in her foreword: "I will gladly leave so many things unsaid, rather than twist them." But Karunakaran does a fantastic job at picking up the nuances left out deliberately, through the fictional work of Pankajam – her poems, and short stories. Having deduced early on that the life of Pankajam's fictional characters closely mirror her grandmother's own journey, Karunakaran teases out a more complete, fulfilling narrative. She uses the wisdom of hindsight to fill in the hazy lines, creating a comprehensive story.

Pankajam emerges as a rather extraordinary woman, one whose sharp mind "rendered her a man" for the time and segment of society she occupied. Forever seeking to free herself from the constraints imposed on her, Pankajam, from an early age, lifts herself up as the aspirational heroine, rising in thought and mind, even while she is tied down to a family bound by patriarchal norms. She writes to counter this, and writing becomes her way out of the less-than-ideal life she might otherwise have been stuck with.

In Pankajam's own words: "My sphere is that of a humble housewife tied to mundane work, which always keeps the soul fettered down. But I write this so that I may show my nearest and dearest how my soul has been ever trying to soar up and break the bondage of the flesh."

The greatest strength of this book is its ability to straddle the personal and intimate while charting a historical journey through troubled times – for both a nation and its women. That makes this a book of much consequence.

Self-respect, she wrote

Moving beyond Periyar's shadow, this anthology highlights the women of the Self-Respect Movement and the caste and gender inequalities they challenged

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In today's Tamil Nadu, most political debates about the Self-Respect Movement centre around 'Periyar' E.V. Ramasamy. This is not surprising: unrestrained and uncompromisingly principled, he often made provocative remarks that are easy fodder for politicians. It is perhaps because of his towering presence that much of the movement, including questions of gender, is still interpreted largely through Periyar's lens.

This is why *The Other Half of the Coconut: Women Writing Self-Respect History* (first published in 2003 and then in 2025), edited by K. Srilata, is important. The two-part book shifts focus from Periyar to a chorus of women who contributed to shaping the intellectual life of the movement. "Such a mapping is crucial... if we wish to understand the complexities of women's agency during the movement," writes Srilata in the preface to the first edition.

The essays have been translated from original speeches and writings in the Tamil, which were published between 1928 and 1936 in Self-Respect journals such as *Kudi Arasu*, *Puratchi*, and *Kumaran*. Together they form what the journalist Caitlin Moran described as a "massive patchwork quilt" – they carry different perspectives and highlight myriad issues, but all the writers stay focused on the movement.

Self-respect was at the heart of the ideology of the movement, and Periyar considered it a precondition for the empowerment of non-Brahmins. The first part of the collection comprises stories, treatises, and essays by women who articulate what self-respect means to them. The first piece, 'What is in store for us?', is about a Brahmin woman, written by Miss and Mrs Kamalakshi. Her name captures her predicament: she is married, but does not live with her husband because her dowry has still not been paid. At first, placing this text upfront

seemed odd to me – why foreground a Brahmin woman's story in an anthology against Brahminism? But that seems to be the intention: to underscore how Brahminical patriarchy, as the scholar Uma Chakravarti put it, pushed even some Brahmins into the fold of the movement.

While Kamalakshi's voice is sad, Trichi Neelavathi's is fiery. In 'Womenfolk and Self-Respect principles', she argues that women, mired in superstition and blind belief, can attain self-respect only through education. Her anger is all the more pronounced in 'Rituals', where she declares: "The Brahmin and no one else is responsible for the growth of rituals. I ask every one of you to courageously

their husbands to finish, and not to eat from soiled leaves. In another essay, she asks why Adi-Dravidars are treated inferior to animals – they are not allowed to draw water from common wells, or use the village pond; the women are not even allowed to wear a blouse. And Jayasekari speaks of the unfairness of women bearing the burden of householdwork.

The second section, *The Dasis' Wicked Snares*, contains excerpts from the 1936 classical work by Moovalur A. Ramamrithammal. Srilata notes that while the novel is not overtly "feminist", depicting the *devadasi*'s life as "one of moral depravity and deceit", it offers "fascinating insights into their lives and demonstrates the creative use of the Self-Respect platform to campaign for the abolition of the *devadasi* system". The story of two *dasi* sisters, Kantha and Ganavathi, combines Moovalur's propagandist abolitionist agenda with a literary narrative that brings their experiences vividly to life.

While the anthology captures the concerns and schisms within the women's movement, some essays revisit similar arguments and issues, which can feel repetitive. Dialogues such as – "Pankajam! To think that you should face such a fate!" cried Visalakshi. "Akka! Wasn't it only yesterday when I, feeling indebted to that useless God, performed the *panchamrita palabhisekham*!" – may for some read like staged exchanges, but the translation simply remains faithful to the theatrical quality of writing of that period.

What I enjoyed is the diversity of forms in the book: journal articles, speeches, short stories, and essays. As a result, the tone also differs. Some essays are highly stylised, some are matter-of-fact, and a few sharply polemical.

Srilata says it is unclear how much women's lives changed immediately after the Self-Respect Movement. But this does not diminish the anthology's value – it is a much-needed addition to the canon of Self-Respect history.



The Other Half of the Coconut: Women Writing Self-Respect History
Edited by K. Srilata
Zubaan
₹525

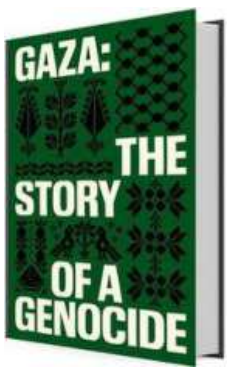
challenge these meaningless rituals."

Rituals and rigid beliefs contribute to the terrible plight of widows – a theme across several essays, including 'Pankajam's tragic death' and Alhaj Subako's essay on Muslim widows. The second underscores how discriminatory practices cut across religion. She writes: "Muslims may pat themselves on the back for being progressive in their attitudes towards widows, but they are merely deceiving themselves."

Several of these writings capture the regressive beliefs of the time. But many others highlight practices that sadly dominate headlines today too. Mu. Maragathavalliyar urges women to have their meals without waiting for



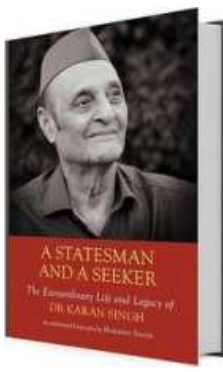
Gaza: The Story of a Genocide
Fatima Bhutto and Sonia Faleiro
Bloomsbury India
₹1,199
Bhutto is co-founder, with Faleiro and Julia Churchill, of Books for Gaza. This collection features personal testimony, poetry, art, and frontline reportage. All royalties will be donated directly to the United Nations Relief and Works Agency (UNRWA) for Palestine refugees in West Asia.



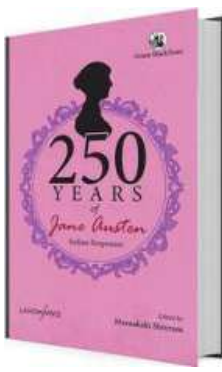
Every Last Girl: A Journey to Educate India's Forgotten Daughters
Safeena Husain
HarperCollins
₹499
Husain, who has worked extensively with rural and urban underserved communities, launched Educate Girls in 2007. In 2025, her organisation received the Ramon Magsaysay Award.



A Statesman and a Seeker: The Extraordinary Life and Legacy of Dr Karan Singh
Harbans Singh
Speaking Tiger Books
₹999
The educationist and editor of *Encyclopaedia of Sikhism* traces Karan Singh's journey from Regent to cabinet minister, Ambassador, scholar, and J&K governor.



250 Years of Jane Austen: Indian Responses
Ed. Meenakshi Shivram
Orient Blackswan
₹1,350
This collection, with a foreword by Jerry Pinto and an afterword by Githa Hariharan, brings together reflections on Austen's poetry, craft, themes, and continuing relevance across film, ecocriticism, and pedagogy.



'Resisting every day and pushing the boundaries, every Iranian has done that'

Sreemoyee Singh

The Kolkata filmmaker's insightful documentary *Be Kucheye Khoshbakht* is a love letter to Iranian cinema, poetry and culture. Shot entirely in Iran over six years (till 2019), in Farsi, this travel diary is replete with intimate conversations with local filmmakers such as Jafar Panahi, actors, scholars, activists and everyday women – to reveal how creativity and resistance flourish under censorship and social repression.

A tragicomic scene spells out the irony. Every time a filmmaker tries to talk about censorship, well-timed construction noise drowns it out. In another scene, Singh sings in Farsi along with a shopkeeper, Panahi by her side. (Singing in public will land you in jail in Iran.) Singh's film also captures women watching and cheering on a football match. In 2018, women were allowed to watch the Fifa World Cup in Tehran. They could sing and rejoice with men at the stadium – an exception to the norm.

The documentary has travelled around the world to more than 50 festivals, and found an address on Mubi in India. Singh is just back from the film's screening at Bengaluru's Christ University, among others.

The filmmaker, who prefers to use the word "resistance" instead of "activism", says, "Resisting every day and pushing the boundaries of what is not allowed, every Iranian has done that." She shares an incident from her time in Iran, when she was travelling in a bus with her friend, a vocal rebel against the government.

"I was very careful about my scarf, but hers would fall off all the time. I'd tell her, 'Do you not want to be careful? What if you're picked up by the cops?' And she said, 'All Iranian women have been picked up by the cops for not wearing the hijab properly. They'll grind you for five-six hours, sometimes for 24 hours, but then you'll be let go of. It's a part of living.' I found that painful to hear."

Singh adds, "After the Mahsa Amini case [the 22-year-old Kurdish Iranian was killed in police custody in 2022], you will see that nobody really wears the veil on the street. Over the years, women have pushed the boundaries of the law on compulsory hijab and the state's idea of modesty."

"People are hurt, angry, shocked" After the recent bombings, Singh has heard back from only one friend in Iran. "This is the longest I haven't been in touch with them," she tells me over the phone. "Nothing is going through. VPNs are not working; messages have single ticks." She mentions meeting a young Iranian filmmaker in Kolkata. Mohammadreza Azadi, 36, came to India just before the bombings to attend DocEdgeKolkata, an international incubation and pitching event for documentary projects. The last conversation he had with his family was that they were evacuating Tehran because of the continued bombings.

"The situation is similar to last year, when Israel first bombed Iran," Singh translates Azadi's words for me. "Everything is closed. A lot of people have evacuated and moved to smaller cities. Many important buildings have been damaged by the bombs; they are destroying Tehran. The non-stop bombings are not targeted. We know about the school [the girls school that was bombed on February 28, killing over 160 people], but there is also the Gandhi Hospital, where there were patients, children, and babies in incubators. And the Golestan Palace, it's destroyed."

A homesick Azadi yearns to return, but the airspace is closed. "People are hurt, angry, shocked and restless. A lot of them are against this attack. We have seen what America's attack on Iraq and Afghanistan did. The people of Iran know that these attacks will not bring happier days," he concludes.



Iranian filmmaker Jafar Panahi in a still from *Be Kucheye Khoshbakht*; and Singh (left).

Defiance enriches art

In the last decade, not many have been making films in Iran because it's mostly state-backed propaganda films that are green-lit, states Sreemoyee Singh. "The crackdown on artists has been increasing. Filmmakers like Manijeh Hekmat, who used to release their films, have stopped making them in Iran. They are looking outward now, for co-productions, and filming outside. I interviewed Jafar Panahi and Mohammad Rasoulof for my Ph.D [on 'The Exiled Filmmaker in Post Revolution Iranian Cinema']. Rasoulof said that every time they took him to prison, he would write his scripts there."

Both Rasoulof and Panahi have been calling out for the world to take note of what is happening in Iran, "calling for help so that people can amplify the cause of Iran," she says. Panahi has been sentenced in absentia to one year in prison and has a travel ban.

Iranian films have earned three Oscar nominations this year – Panahi picking up two for *It Was Just An Accident* (Best International Feature and Best Original Screenplay), and debutants Mohammadreza Eyni and Sara Khaki for *Cutting Through Rocks* (Best Documentary Feature). "It's not easy to throttle artists because they'll always find a way to a language to express themselves," adds Singh.

Understanding Iran through pop culture

Sreemoyee Singh's documentary *Be Kucheye Khoshbakht* And, Towards Happy Alleys (2023) is more relevant than ever at the moment. The filmmaker urges that people "follow Iranians [on social media]" and listen to them talking about what's happening. "What comes out might be conflicted, but now is the time for us to listen to the stories coming out of Iran, without any judgement. We should educate ourselves about the history of Iran, and watch its cinema." Singh, who studied Persian in Tehran, encourages to start by reading books and watching films by Iranians. "Marjane Satrapi's *Persepolis* 1 and 2 are nice," she says.

"Modern poetry by Sohrab Sepehri, Forugh Farrokhzad and Ahmad Shamlou; cinema that has been critical of the regime, like *Offside* (2006), *Crimson Gold* (2003), and *Taxi* (2015) by Panahi; *Where is the Friend's House?* (1987), *Taste of Cherry* (1997), and *Ten* (2002) by Abbas Kiarostami; *A Moment of Innocence* (1996) and *The Silence* (1998) by Mohsen Makhmalbaf," she says.

HER LENS ON IRAN

CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



Shumali Khullar Shroff

It isn't every day someone casually mentions they are heading back to a cabin near the North Pole. Yet, that is exactly what 57-year-old Hilde Fåln Strøm, a citizen scientist based in Longyearbyen, the world's northernmost town, told me when we met last year in the frozen archipelago of Svalbard.

Norwegian by nationality, Strøm grew up outside Oslo in a family that spent long days outdoors. Her passion for the Arctic began in childhood and deepened after she moved to Svalbard in 1995, where she lives with her husband Steinar, who works for Statsbygg and oversees properties owned by the Longyearbyen government. The two have lovely grandchildren.

An explorer, polar ambassador and climate advocate, Strøm runs Svalbard Expeditions and is the co-founder, with Sunniva Sorby, of Hearts in the Ice, a pioneering citizen-science initiative. She advocates for Arctic protection through global platforms such as COP26 and contributes to projects like Arctic Call, an Inuit-led summit integrating traditional knowledge with modern climate monitoring. This year, it is slated for September 11-15.

When I visited the region, it was early spring, and Svalbard was buried under snow. The sun didn't set at all, yet no trees grew. The starkness felt almost extraterrestrial, and yet inviting. No wonder it held Strøm so firmly.

"When I return from the cabin," she told me, "it is never with stories of solitude or survival. It is always science, encounters with polar bears, and a kind of happiness I cannot quite describe." Bamsébu, the cabin, is a 20 sq.m structure built in 1930 for summer beluga hunting. There is no insulation, electricity or plumbing. "No heating either, unless you count the wood stove," she said. "I have been collecting driftwood for years."

Absolute isolation Longyearbyen is a land of glaciers and fjords, midnight sun and unending polar night. For part of the year, daylight never ends; for months afterwards it never begins. The trapper cabin Strøm referenced intensifies all of this: glacier winds, the silence of the tundra, and the absence of human life except for polar bears and reindeer. "It is 145 km as the crow flies,"



(Clockwise from below) Hilde Fåln Strøm in her trapper cabin in Bamsébu; her husky Ettra by the shore of Van Keulen Fjord (Van Keulenfjorden) in the remote Arctic region of Svalbard; and Strøm with her husky. (COURTESY HILDE FÅLN STRØM)



INTERNATIONAL WOMEN'S DAY
ON A CLIMATE MISSION TO NORTH POLE

Inside the Arctic cabin of Hilde Fåln Strøm – 19 months, 104 polar bears, and a call to save the planet

Strøm explained. "But the route cuts across glaciers, mountain ridges and two fjords that must be frozen solid to cross. It is not a casual commute." She travelled by snowmobile, towing a sledge loaded with 400 kg of food, fuel, equipment, and sometimes her husky.

There was the time when a storm she likened to a hurricane ripped the windshield off her snowmobile. "It flew off and landed between two ice blocks by the open sea," she said. "I just leapt off and grabbed it before it blew into the water." When she reached the cabin, she often had to dig through drifts to reach the door.

These short trips were nothing compared with the 19 months she once spent at Bamsébu with Sorby as part of a citizen science expedition. It had long been Strøm's dream to live as close to the North Pole as possible, but not alone.

"And it was not going to be my husband," she laughed. She met Sorby, a Canadian, at a trade fair in Alaska in 2019. Soon after, the two were packing supplies for a winter of isolation in the frozen Arctic. Their plan was to stay nine months. COVID-19 stretched the expedition to nearly two years. "We got a satellite message with a single word: epidemic," Strøm said. "We did not have radio or TV. By the time we understood the enormity of it, no ships were coming. We were not exactly stranded, but we could not leave either."

Even if they could have, they did not want to. "We had too much equipment, and there were polar bears in the area. Abandoning food stores would have been



irresponsible. And scientists could not access the field. We were the only ones reporting on long-term studies of polar bears and the tundra." Despite limited satellite bandwidth, their research reached far. "We spoke to 104,000 children," Strøm said.

Wild encounters Polar bears, she explained, struggle to survive without sea ice from which to hunt seals. They are among the species most vulnerable to climate change. "The Arctic is twice as vulnerable as the rest of the world to climate change. We wanted students to understand how melting glaciers here could reshape the entire planet."

Strøm still marvels that she saw 104 different polar bears. One night, a bear slammed into the cabin wall and climbed onto the roof. "I grabbed my revolver, flare gun and rubber bullets and stepped outside.

He was 30 m away. We locked eyes. Then he walked off."

Her days began at 7 am. She lit the stove, chopped ice blocks to melt and boiled water. Later in the year, the women melted snow or used a nearby stream. Meals were simple: oatmeal or granola for breakfast, reindeer or Arctic char for dinner. "We even had a tiny solar- and wind-powered freezer."

Strøm walked her dog Ettra daily, even in storms and months of darkness, with lights on the dog's collar and heat-sensing binoculars to spot danger. The women exercised each day, washed their hair every two weeks using melted snow, washed clothes "in the same bucket", and dried everything "by the stove".

Still a woman

One day, the new priest of Svalbard arrived by helicopter, carrying "fruits, vegetables and my husband", Strøm recalled. Even in extremity, the women preserved small rituals. "I wore a dress on Christmas and New Year's Eve," she said. "Curled my hair. Put on makeup. It reminded me of who I was, strong, yes, but still a woman."

For those brief two hours, she and her husband "stood outside, holding hands in the snow, singing about how lucky we were to be alive. It was one of the most powerful moments of overwintering". Overwintering taught Strøm how little one needs in life to be happy. How everything is interconnected, that we are not only part of nature, we are nature. And how much fun it is to be part of the solution, not the problem.

What about a toilet, I ask. "For the first six months, we went to the shoreline, 40 m away. Not fun in a blizzard for a woman." But "this was not a retreat. It was resistance, against disconnection from the planet, against apathy in the face of climate change", she said.

Beyond the data and the ice, Strøm's legacy lies in her mission to cultivate more heartbeats in leadership, by bringing together women leaders, indigenous voices and traditional knowledge with modern science to address the climate crisis. "Women are caretakers. We are resilient. If we educate girls around the world, we do not just save the planet, we create a more peaceful, sustainable world," she concluded.

The writer is a Mumbai based author and cultural commentator.



WORLD WILDLIFE DAY | MARCH 3

GIBBONS ON THE BRINK

As their numbers crash from 100,000 to under 5,000, stress tests and tech solutions come to the rescue



estimated 100,000 individuals to less than 5,000.

Addressing these overlapping threats to the western hoolock gibbon requires more than isolated research or localised interventions. Increasingly, this work is being coordinated through The Habitats Trust (THT), a Delhi-based conservation organisation that acts as a platform bringing together field scientists, local NGOs, technologists and community actors to address gaps in data, monitoring and long-term protection of species across fragmented landscapes in Northeast India.

Studying genetics and stress The challenges faced by gibbons are emblematic of pressures on low-lying rainforests in Northeast India, says Rushikesh Chavan,

director of THT. He adds that changing land use and *jhum* cultivation are key threats to the species. "Previously, these cycles of slashing and burning

would last decades, where forests would be destroyed and then allowed to regenerate. However, these cycles have now come down from decades to just 7-10 years due

(Clockwise from left) Conservationists on the lookout for gibbons in Jorhat, Assam; a female hoolock gibbon; and rope bridges to facilitate gibbon passage over the Northeast Frontier Railway line. Till date, no gibbons have been recorded using them. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



to pressures on the local communities," he says.

Udayan Borthakur, director and head of Wildlife Genetics Laboratory (WGL) at Aaranyak, a conservation NGO in Guwahati, says that gibbon populations have become "small and isolated" across their range. "We are trying to study source populations, which could be in the Garo Hills, Dehing Patkai and even Hollongapar."

Aaranyak is now compiling genetic data of gibbon populations through faecal matter collected in forests to understand whether in-breeding and in-breeding depression are causes for concern. "Through these analyses, we are trying to identify the source populations. For instance, in Hollongapar, our research will show if this current population has increased from a smaller population of a few individuals or if they are descended from a larger pre-existing population," he says.

WGL is also studying stress levels of gibbon populations in different areas, to understand whether hormones such as cortisol are higher in populations that are in closer proximity to human settlements and other anthropogenic pressures.

Tech-based solutions

Many of the technology-based solutions now being explored for gibbon conservation have emerged directly from challenges identified by field researchers. To address the difficulty of monitoring an arboreal and highly vocal species such as the western hoolock gibbon, THT, working together with Shillong non-profit Conservation Initiatives, and technologists, has been developing bio-acoustic and thermal imaging tools that can complement on-ground surveys. Thermal drones are also being explored for the possibility of detecting gibbons in a landscape using a computer vision model.

These efforts position THT as a central coordinating hub, translating conservation needs articulated by scientists and communities into scalable, field-ready solutions, says Chavan.

Community help

Local communities, too, are becoming involved in the conservation of the species. There are over a hundred tribes, each with their unique laws and customs related to forest conservation and hunting, says Diya Vasudev, co-founder and senior scientist at Conservation Initiatives. "Some tribes prohibit the hunting of gibbons, but we need to bring more on board to ensure the protection of the species," she adds. "The more villages we work with and the more people that show conservation support and ensure there is some forest secure on their lands, the better. The main thrust has to come from the community."



ALLEGEDLY

Becoming Tiger Papa

'As an Indian father, you should not be doing Chinese parenting,' my son was quick to point out

you read this, I am hiding it."

"Give it to me!"

"No!"

As I tried to grab the book, my elbow tipped over a glass of water, which dropped to the floor and broke into a million little pieces. Hearing the crash, Wife rushed down. "Not one minute of peace in this house! Don't you have a column to write or something? Why are you harassing him?"

"Hello! I am harassing him?"

Why don't you –

"I don't have time for this," she said. "I have a client call in two minutes."

"Papa is threatening to become super-strict, like a Tiger Papa."

She looked at Katta's face, then at the book he was clutching. "You mean he wants to be like Tiger Mom?" She burst out laughing.

"What's so funny?" I said. "I look forward to the day your hyper-woke Papa becomes a Tiger Papa," she said, retreating up the stairs. "Guys, clean up before someone cuts their foot!"

"What is hyper-woke?" Katta wanted to know.

"It means someone who always says and does the right thing."

Katta took a minute to absorb that. "Mum is right," he said. "You do the right thing, most of the time. That's

why you can't apply Tiger Mom techniques on me."

"How so?"

"Because it would be wrong. Didn't you tell me consent is most important when one person has power over another?"

"Yes, but –"

"You have power over me. I don't consent to Chinese parenting."

"But it's for your own good."

"You also told me that's what they all say, the bad men – they say it's for your own good."

"Alright," I said. "I won't apply anything until you've read the full book."

"Promise?"

"Promise."

Two days later, he handed it back. "It's a stupid book."

"Show me one stupid thing."

He flipped a few pages and began to read. "The Chinese mother believes that

schoolwork always comes first, and if your child ever disobeys with a teacher or coach, you must always take the side of the teacher or coach."

He looked up. "So, next time I have a complaint about any teacher, you will automatically take the teacher's side?"

I opened my mouth. Then I closed it. The thing is, I've always drilled it into Katta to question authority – teachers, coaches, experts, everyone.

I picked up the book.

Student alary club's hallgathers

– Sophia's Carnegie Hall debut, their Harvard acceptances – and then I looked at Katta. A nine-year-old who'd just dismantled a parenting philosophy using the random stuff I'd filled his head with.

I put the book down. "Fine," I said. "You win."

Katta smiled, not the smile of a child let off the hook, but the smile of a teacher granting a well-deserved 'A' to his most frustrating student.

Which, I suppose, is the closest either of us will ever get to tiger parenting.

G. Sampath, the author of this satire, is Social Affairs Editor, The Hindu.

Dear readers, wherever you are in the world at this moment, I hope you are safe and well.

I am particularly thinking of all you children reading this. It must all seem so scary and horrible to read the news. Especially, when you see what is happening to other children in other places. You might also feel a little powerless.

What can I do, you are thinking to yourself, perhaps. After all, I am just a child.

But even the smallest child can change things, my friend. You are small in size, but you are huge in spirit.

You can do things. You can hug your siblings. You can be nice to your friends. You can support people who are having a bad day. But, most of all, you can choose to be nice to everyone, whether you know them or not. You have the power to make that choice. And you never know when someone out there just needs a kind word from a child. Suddenly, their day is a hundred times better. Just imagine having that kind of power, no? And you have it.

Then maybe in 10 or 15 years’ time, you will look back on all this and say: it was very bad. But we made it better.

Very good. So, back to the main programming.

Sometime in the year 1990 or so, I was rummaging around in my parents’ private cupboard. This was the cupboard in which my parents kept the most valuable family possessions such as passports, visas, property papers, birth certificates and the very expensive foreign chocolate that we all ate, once every month, 10 grams at a time.

School had closed for summer



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

vacations. And I was bored. So without asking for permission, I just opened the cupboard and rummaged through things. And I discovered a large, thick envelope full of extremely strange papers.

“What is this?” I asked my mother.

“Never ever mention that envelope in this house again,” she said. “Especially never mention it to your father.”

Which is why merely hours later, even before my father had stepped one foot into the house when he returned from work, I shoved the envelope in his face and demanded clarification.

TRICKTIONARY EPISODE 27

PROFITS IN THE RUBBLE

When human tragedy is just another stock market opportunity

Gloombergs
/ˈɡluːmbɜːɡz/
noun (plural)
Definition: The species of investor or financial commentator who, upon receiving news of any human catastrophe, geopolitical crisis or act of war, immediately and instinctively converts said tragedy into a set of market observations, portfolio recommendations, and asset reallocation strategies.
Related forms
Gloomberging (verb): The act of converting a humanitarian crisis into a investment opportunity in real time.
Gloomberged (verb, past tense): To have subjected others to unsolicited financial analysis during a moment of collective grief.

He quietly walked to the dining table, sat down, and then called me over.

“In all my life, Sidin, I have only ever invested in the stock market twice. These are the documents.”

“Say no more!” I said to my father. “I will not let this wealth change who I am. When I inherit these riches from you in 10 or 15 years, I will try and be humble in my interactions with all people. Don’t worry, dad. Also, if I move to Monaco, will you be willing to relocate with me?”

And then, my father opened the envelope and showed me the share certificates. They were for two companies named Andhra Scooters and Orkay Silks.

They were worth approximately nothing rupees and nothing paisa per share.

Ever since then, my dear friends, I have treated the stock market with the same approach as a chicken with a *tandoor*.

I don’t understand it. I don’t know how it works. I don’t trust it. I will have nothing to do with it.

Unfortunately, when you reach the age that I have, namely late 40s, a surprising number of people suddenly want to talk to you about the stock market.

Within minutes of hostilities breaking out recently, my WhatsApp was flooded with people saying things like: “This is such a human tragedy, however is this a good opportunity to buy defence stocks? Should I exit my India portfolio?” Or “War is never the answer? Also should I increase gold in my asset allocation?”

Friends, I have two questions. First, why are people like this? And second, why is there no word in the English language to describe such chicanery? Enough is enough.

Henceforth, we shall call such people: gloombergs.

Example sentence: “During our final company meeting, when he announced the company was being shut down, our gloomberg CEO told us that while this was a difficult moment for everyone, the one silver lining was that we could all now buy our competitor’s stock.”

Are you surrounded by gloombergs? Just tell them you have put all your money in fixed deposits. They will never talk to you again. Congratulations.



Sidin Vadukut helps early stage companies communicate better. He blogs at www.whatay.com.

GOREN BRIDGE

Perseverance

Neither vulnerable, North deals

Bob Jones

Today’s deal is from a recent tournament in India. South had been a star player in India for many decades, but he

was in his 80s now and had lost some of his patience. He showed that in both his bidding and his play on this deal. South won the opening trump lead in his hand and drew the rest of the trumps. Seeing nothing

NORTH		EAST	
♠ A 10 8 4	♥ A K J 5	♠ Q 9 7 6 2	♥ Q 10 8 7
♦ J	♣ A J 9 7	♦ 5 3	♣ K 10
WEST		SOUTH	
♠ K J 3	♥ 4 3	♠ 5	♥ 9 6 2
♦ 8 7	♣ Q 8 6 4 3 2	♦ A K Q 10 9 6 4 2	♣ 5

The bidding:			
NORTH	EAST	SOUTH	WEST
1♣	Pass	6♦	Pass
7♦	All pass		

Opening lead: Eight of ♦

better to do, he took the heart finesse at trick three and was quickly down one.

There were some extra chances on this deal, and expert discussion sorted through them at the end of the day. It was possible that

one opponent started with three clubs to the king and queen. After drawing trumps, South might have led a club to the ace and ruffed a club. The fall of the king would be exciting! Declarer could now cash

two high hearts, in case the queen fell, and ruff another club. East’s discard would be disappointing, but South could now start to run his diamonds. This would be the position with one diamond to go:

On the two of diamonds, West would have to keep his club, so would part with a spade. The jack of clubs would be discarded from dummy and East would have the Hobson’s choice of discarding a spade or a heart. 13 tricks for South either way!

NORTH		EAST	
♠ A 10	♥ Void	♠ Q 9	♥ Q
♦ Void	♣ Void	♦ Void	♣ Void
♣ J		♣ J	
SOUTH			
♠ 6	♥ 9		
♦ 2	♣ Void		

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

Wonderful women!



Mary Anderson was travelling through New York in 1902 when she noticed a streetcar driver struggling to see through the sleet and snow. What did she invent that is now standard in every automobile? (GETTY IMAGES)

Berty Ashley

Judith Love Cohen was pregnant while working on a problem in the “Abort Guidance System,” without which a historic event would never have happened. She went into labour, kept working, solved the problem, and was then taken to the hospital, where she delivered Jack Black (the actor) a few days later. If he was born on August 28, 1969, what project was she working on?

Stephanie Kwolek was a chemist working at DuPont, experimenting with polymers intended to create stronger car tyres. By accident, she created an unusually strong, lightweight fibre that her colleagues initially dismissed because it looked cloudy in solution. What did she create that now saves countless lives in protective gear worldwide?

Mary Anderson was travelling through New York in 1902 when she noticed a streetcar driver struggling to see through sleet and snow. She designed a hand-operated blade system to help drivers maintain visibility. What did she invent that is now standard in every automobile?

Virginia Apgar devised a system now known as the “APGAR Score.” It evaluates Appearance (skin colour), Pulse, Grimace (reflex irritability), Activity (muscle tone), and Respiration. It is used worldwide to assess which important group of patients?

Ann Tsukamoto was part of the team that developed the first patented method to isolate specific blood-forming cells from bone marrow. This breakthrough became foundational for cancer research, bone marrow transplants, and regenerative

medicine worldwide. What type of cells was this method designed to isolate?

In the 1960s, Marie Van Brittan Brown was concerned about slow police response times in her neighbourhood in New York. To improve home safety, she designed a system with peepholes, a sliding camera, television monitors, and a remote door-unlock feature. What technology did she pioneer?

In the 1980s, Radia Perlman solved a major problem in computer networking – preventing loops that could crash entire systems when multiple paths existed between machines. Her elegant algorithm allowed networks to organise themselves efficiently. This led to the functioning of which global system?

Shirley Jackson’s research in the 1970s explored how subatomic particles behave and how signals travel through different materials. Her work contributed to innovations that made high-speed data transmission and modern telecommunications networks possible worldwide. Her research led to which technology, of which 1.5 million kilometres lie beneath the ocean?

Dorothy Hodgkin used X-ray crystallography to determine the three-dimensional structures of complex biological molecules. Her work revealed the structure of penicillin and later two life-saving substances used worldwide to treat anaemia and diabetes. Which two crucial molecules did she successfully map?

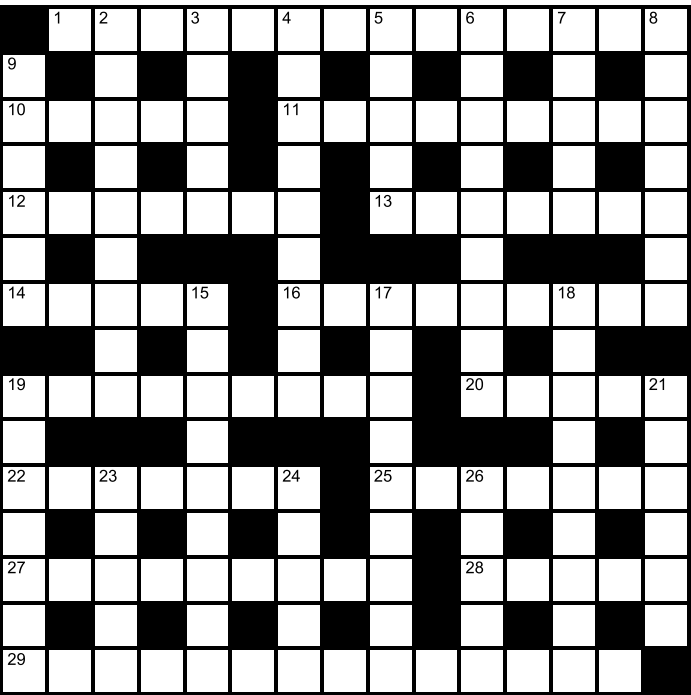
Gladys West was a mathematician working for the U.S. Navy in the 1970s who developed complex mathematical models to accurately determine the shape of the Earth. Her calculations were critical in refining satellite data to enable precise navigation. Her work became essential to a technology that many people rely on daily.

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called ‘Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion’. @bertyashley

- 1. Apollo 11 landing
- 2. Keplar
- 3. Windshield Wiper
- 4. Newborn babies
- 5. Stem Cells
- 6. CCTV (Closed Circuit Television)
- 7. Internet
- 8. Fiber Optics
- 9. Vitamin B12 / Insulin
- 10. GPS

Answers

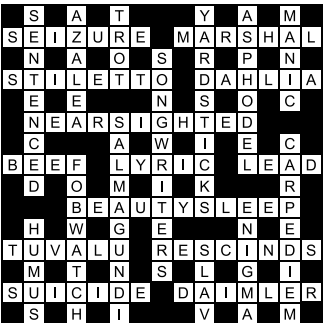
THE SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 46 (Set by Arden)



- Across**
- 1 A man on either side of police party — the head of state is a polymath (3,2,4,5)
 - 10 Calling for service in court (5)
 - 11 Record gold — detailed post indicates the rank (9)
 - 12 Heavy responsibility over lifting the mineral (7)
 - 13 A country taking a leaf (from the top) out of another (7)
 - 14 Exercise concluded finally by the stream (5)
 - 16 Prime adjustment goes into money for carpet (9)
 - 19 Mustangs take years to train for rapid eye movement (9)
 - 20 Finally, purge by any other name is still a purge (5)
 - 22 Part of government holding is recovered from mint (7)
 - 25 Fish cut and consumed first (7)
 - 27 Setter accommodates kennels (3,6)
 - 28 Done three times to get rid of husband in an instant (5)
 - 29 Windcheater in turn is part of the fireworks (9,5)

- 5 One of many — a lazy beast in custody (5)
- 6 Light inset maybe for a disputed territory (9)
- 7 It turns both ways (5)
- 8 Set out for a tie-up with a flight attendant (7)
- 9 Tender for electric wire (6)
- 15 See them as breaking internal order — it’s terrible (9)
- 17 Spooner’s landlord will fix in double quick time (4-5)
- 18 After a study, discover one is part of our DNA (9)
- 19 Not late in moving declamation — always on the move (7)
- 21 A thankless job protecting these joints (6)
- 23 Thing about darkness (5)
- 24 Health drink for a girl, second time (5)
- 26 Leave the trench (5)

SOLUTION NO. 45



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Every night at 2 a.m., tribal families in Rajpur tehsil of Barwani district in Madhya Pradesh wake up. By 4 a.m., nearly 10,000 labourers, including even children as young as six and elders nearing 80, crowd the local market, hoping to get a day’s work. They earn between ₹300 and ₹350, but after paying for a bumpy bus ride to Nimad or Maharashtra, many take home just ₹100. They slog through tough jobs, lifting, digging, hauling, and travelling until 9 p.m., stumbling back exhausted with no time for family, festivals, or even proper rest. This isn’t a choice; it is a question of survival.

As a PGDRM student at the Institute of Rural Management Anand, I studied livelihood patterns in villages of Rajpur block as part of the programme’s two-month Village Fieldwork Segment (VFS). The study reveals that about 90% of these households rely on work in other places, and almost 100% belong to marginalised Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe communities. “My father migrated, so I will too,” one of them said.

Many reasons for migration
Among the many reasons for this daily grind, the dying farming stands tall. The hilly land gets no irrigation, enabling only one-time cropping a year. The Situation Assessment Survey of Agricultural Households (77th Round, January-December 2018) of the National Sample Survey Organisation reported that the estimated average monthly income of agricultural households was ₹10,218, but in Rajpur, migrants barely make it. It’s a cycle of poverty that has kept families stuck for generations.

Government initiatives to alleviate poverty have yielded limited results. The Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (MGNREGS), now revamped to Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin), meant to provide 100 days of work in a year, remained underutilised in Rajpur. Being a tribal area designated under the Panchayats Extension to Scheduled Areas (PESA) Act, Rajpur faces barriers in accessing the scheme. Many villagers are unaware of it, and about 30%, especially women, lack Aadhaar-linked bank accounts, making direct benefit transfers impossible. As a result, its benefits have not percolated to PESA areas, leaving households dependent on work outside.

Limited alternatives
Such work is neither sustainable for everyone nor viable in the long term. Yet, some still manage to find a way out. For instance, Jasma Di, once a migrant labourer, joined a women’s self-help group supported by NGOs and a farmer-producer company, using a loan to start a small horticulture farm. Today, she earns ₹35,000 to ₹40,000 a month – well above the all-India average income of agricultural households (₹10,218, NSSO 2018) and her children attend school instead of travelling with her for work. Some families have explored other options such as raising chickens or goats, which pay better than the ₹300 a day. But here’s the catch: only 5-10% of families pull this off. For most, it’s a dream too big to touch.

Why can’t everyone do it? Money’s the wall. After talking to local farmers and experts, we learned it takes about ₹1 lakh to start a horticulture farm and more money for water pipes, seeds, fertilizers, and more. With ₹300 a day, saving that takes years, especially when bus fares chew up half of it. SHG

The pen seller in the mean streets

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A few months ago, a short video was shared widely on social media. An old man stood at a traffic signal with a bunch of pens. When someone tried to give him money, he refused. He said he was not begging. He was selling pens.

People liked that. Many comments praised his self-respect. Some people went back and bought more pens than they needed. Buying felt better than giving money. It felt fair. Once you notice it, you see this everywhere. At traffic lights, outside metro stations, near temples and markets, people sell small things. Pens, handkerchiefs, flags, balloons. The items change. The set-up stays the same.

A pen that costs a few rupees is sold for 20 or 50. No one is buying it for the pen. The pen is only there to complete the exchange.

Selling changes how need is seen. It makes the situation easier to deal with. The buyer feels they did something right. The seller gets cash. The moment ends.

When something works, others copy it. Not because anyone planned it. Simply because it brings money. Slowly, it becomes normal.

What gets missed is the harder question. Why is this the best option available? Once need is shown as effort, the larger problem fades away.

Selling pens does not fix jobs, housing, or support systems. It only makes these problems easier to live with. The situation stays the same.

The job of the individual is to care. The job of the state is to reduce the need for these exchanges.

Inside the daily struggles of itinerant labourers

For the tribal families of Rajpur, life is a 2 a.m. wake-up call to earn just enough for bare survival for another day

Workers return late at night in an open goods vehicles after a full day of manual labour outside their village in Rajpur block of Barwani district in Madhya Pradesh.
(MOHIT RAGHUWANSHI)



loans, usually ₹50,000-₹60,000, don’t cover it all. Plus, crops take four to six months to grow, and families living on ₹100 a day can’t wait that long without food.

This is where the National Rural Livelihoods Mission (NRLM), a flagship scheme of the Government of India, comes in. Launched in 2011, the NRLM aims to lift rural families out of poverty by promoting sustainable livelihoods through SHGs, where women pool savings and access credit. It provides loans to SHGs, typically ₹50,000 to ₹1 lakh, repayable over one to three years with monthly instalments. With a 97% repayment rate (Rural Development Ministry, 2022), the scheme shows promise, though loan amounts remain too small for projects such as horticulture farms requiring ₹1 lakh upfront. Paperwork slows things down, especially in remote areas. In tribal Rajpur, where many don’t even know about the NRLM, awareness is a major hurdle. So, while Jasma Di thrives with her SHG loan, most families remain in the dark.

Drawing from our study, we propose some fixes. First, rural credit must expand in both scale and size. During our fieldwork, most SHG members reported receiving loans of around ₹50,000 to ₹60,000. Larger loans could enable horticulture, as seen in Jasma Di’s case, but existing limits are inadequate. Evidence shows Kisan Credit Cards raise farm incomes by 25-30% (Meena & Reddy, 2013). With NRLM’s 97% repayment rate, higher,

The estimated average monthly income of agricultural households is ₹10,218; government initiatives to alleviate poverty have yielded limited results

tailored loans in PESA regions are low-risk and essential.

Second, equally important is irrigation. Farmers in Rajpur want to grow cash crops such as turmeric or cotton, but lack reliable water. A World Bank study in South India (2021) showed that small-scale irrigation systems such as drip and check dams raise farm income, and similar measures in Rajpur could make diversification viable and reduce migration.

Third, our fieldwork revealed that local leaders and villagers in Rajpur lack awareness of their constitutional rights and government schemes. The Rashtriya Gram Swaraj Abhiyan, launched in 2018 and revamped in 2022, aims to strengthen panchayat raj institutions, including in PESA regions, through capacity-building and training.

Mobile camps
Fourth, programme outreach and local governance need strengthening. Expanding access to the employment guarantee scheme through mobile camps would help families enroll for Aadhaar and bank accounts, making it possible to claim the 100 days of guaranteed work. At the same time, leadership capacity is crucial.

Finally, introduce a transitional cash support mechanism for tribal households seeking to shift from itinerant labour to horticulture or other sustainable livelihoods. A temporary cash transfer – targeted and time-bound – could offer vital income security during the four to six months between investment and returns. Labour in other places is not Rajpur’s fate; it’s what happens when no one cares enough. Jasma Di shows what’s possible: a life rooted in home, not on a bus. SHGs and NGOs spark change, but they are drops in a bucket. For the 10,000 waking before dawn, children missing school, and elders breaking their backs, the government has to step up.

The great corporate laughter challenge

When a company tried to schedule happiness, the joke was on it



would come alive with young techies pulling each other’s legs. Even greying veterans – the crusty old guard – was not above offering one liners and fun liners.

Joke-and-dagger
But in HR’s eyes, these were islands of fun amid an ocean of dreary routine, and clearly not adequate. Like justice, it was not enough that a congenial atmosphere prevailed, it had to be seen to prevail. Our stealthy joke-and-dagger operations would, therefore, need to be replicated in the glare of the quadrangle, obvious even to the hurried visitor. The boss too bought into the idea that injecting humour into the everyday agenda would spark

employee creativity and improve morale. She rose to the occasion by assuring HR that she would go many steps further than their prescriptions – she wouldn’t just get people to smile, she would make them laugh heartily. The operation got itself a codename – Ha Ha Happenings!

A raft of activities was planned – from commissioning a stand-up comedian, to sticking off-beat posters on the walls, and organising a Friday afternoon session titled “Tickle *aur* Pickle”.

Buoyed by the occasion, enthusiasts proposed a skit that would parody our response to current developments such as AI and the more befuddling AQI.

Suddenly, the project bristled with unexpected problems. Finding a stand-up artiste suitable for corporate audiences was like finding a diamond in the Deonar dump yard because for most contemporary comedians, expletives came more readily than punctuations. And then, the spectre of political correctness reared its head. When we got down to it, there seemed to be a severe drought of subjects that you could joke about and live to tell the tale. Even the celebrated R.K. Laxman in his later years had said that his ‘Common Man’ was afraid to laugh in case someone got offended!

Soon, even its most ardent supporters conceded that the project had not lived up to its billing. Those who did laugh at the jokes did so out of deference rather than delight. At the end, we discovered a profound truth – you cannot mainstream what flourishes best on the margins, and when humour is institutionalised, it stops being fun.

The only happy postscript was that the laughter campaign itself became the subject of a million memes. A veteran who had seen corporate trends ebb and flow, summed it up, saying “it’s time to bid ta-ta to ha-ha”. As usual, the old guard had the last laugh.



FEEDBACK
Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

▼ Cover story
Future of India’s AI sector is promising, especially after the Delhi Declaration, which stressed responsible, inclusive, and innovation-driven technology. (‘India’s AI reckoning’, March 1) India’s techno-optimism, backed by its vast digital public infrastructure, skilled talent pool, and startup ecosystem, positions the country as a global AI hub. With ethical governance, and upskilling, AI could significantly accelerate India’s economic growth and social transformation.
N.S. Reddy

▼
We are entering a future where AI will deeply integrate into our lives, revolutionising and enhancing human capabilities in countless ways. In medical research and personalised healthcare, AI will play a dominant role, improving diagnostic accuracy. It will also replace human roles in critical tasks, such as self-driving cars in AI-managed smart cities. In a country like India, grappling with unemployment, AI should be used as a tool for job enrichment rather than job replacement.
T.N. Venugopalan

▼
The cover story is insightful. There is a need for AI to be more human-centric rather than a mere machine learning tool. Amid the clutter of deepfake technologies, ensuring children’s safety in AI-driven apps will be of paramount importance.
G. Ramasubramanyam

▼ Learning about Periyar
Not many outside Tamil Nadu are aware of the revolutionary social reform movement that was led by Periyar E.V. Ramasamy. (‘Periyar for a non-Tamil reading public’, March 1) The movement has had a lasting impact on Tamil society. This book, put together by A.R. Venkatachalapathy and Karthick Ram Manoharan, will help people outside Tamil Nadu understand the ideology of Periyar, and how it shaped the unique journey the State has charted towards progress.
Kosaraju Chandramouli

▼ For posterity
Contemporary reuse of historic building not only helps preserve the structure but also boosts tourism. (‘Heritage is worth investing in’, March 1) This will give the future generation an opportunity to showcase our rich culture.
Gopika A. Gopan

▼ Beacon of change
Women have myriad skills and this has been proved even in the field of priesthood. (‘Nandini Bhowmik: bridging the gap’, March 1) Bhowmik is an excellent example for women who are passionate about the Vedas and mantras, and wish to spread their message of positivity and inclusion, especially among the youth.
Ratna Naidu

▼ Preserving tradition
It was quite surprising to discover the story of chairs, a topic that is rarely discussed. (‘Take a seat’, March 1) I have great admiration for the curators whose steadfast commitment to preserving India’s diverse architectural styles deserves recognition.
Sajna Hameed

 **MORE ON THE WEB**
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▼ Choking construction
Construction dust is visible, but tolerated and rarely interrogated with seriousness
Darsheel Erish Nair

The cost of constant productivity
The common response is to push harder, work longer, and silence whatever feels inconvenient
Nirmala S.

How women negotiate the world
They learn to read rooms, anticipate reactions, and measure consequences
Shyma Begum

The blind spots
From private quirks to patterns in public life, recognising them is the first step toward understanding and change
Jameel Ahmed

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10 years later, Lodhi Art District is not only a commentary on public art, but also an important experiment in private-public partnerships

Maanav Jalan

Large letters crawl over a blue wall, spelling out questions on water and access. Another wall has portraits of women teaching their children. Elsewhere, there are abstractions in black and white, and colourful spray-painted silhouettes, as though viewed through a rain-splattered window.

In February, the murals in Delhi's Lodhi Colony went up to 66. As the public 'art district', which began as an experiment in 2015 by the St+art India Foundation, turned 10, six new works took up residence. This included a collaborative one by U.K.-based Raissa Pardini and the late artist and St+art co-founder Hanif Kureshi. The mural, which centred on issues of water scarcity, drew on the artists' long-term exchanges with sign painters in Old Delhi.

"We wanted to leave a cultural legacy in our cities, which were being overrun with commercial advertisements," says co-founder Arjun Bahl, speaking to the scale and ambition of the district, developed around the same time as India's Smart Cities Mission. Despite being founded through organic meetings among friends, much of its early (and continued) momentum was gained through partnerships with local government bodies, embassies and private companies. If public art was to be rethought as urban infrastructure, a bridge had to be made between street art's counter-cultural instincts and the institutions that

could grant it scale and longevity. He recalls entering a police station for the first time in 2014, to get permissions for a 150-foot-tall mural. The group pitched a portrait of Mahatma Gandhi to be painted on the side facade of the Delhi police headquarters. The interaction opened a relationship with the Delhi police, which has been developing ever since. For Bahl, conversations with such "stakeholders" are necessary, emphasising that "our only agenda is to put art out there".

Sites of cultural diplomacy Still, producing culture in public spaces is a continuous process of re-negotiation. Speaking of recent challenges, a production manager at St+art talks about the "complicated task of managing the building society, government, police, and artists", the long list of people who can stake claim over a community space. "People in government change, so we have to start conversations afresh," Bahl explains. "Fortunately, we have a well-documented body of work as precedent, which makes it easier."

The morning of our conversation, Bahl had been with the Spanish president, Indian culture minister and British deputy prime minister, touring the Lodhi Art District during their visit to Delhi for the India AI Impact Summit. These gestures of "cultural diplomacy" speak to the funding structures that have supported St+art since its inception. Suso33, one of the artists invited to contribute in 2026, was flown in by Spain as part of the 'India-Spain



Dual Year of Culture, Tourism and Artificial Intelligence'. Meanwhile, the Goethe Institut is one of St+art's first financial supporters. The other, Asian Paints, has become Lodhi Art



(Clockwise from far left) Berlin-based artist Jumu at work; new murals in Lodhi Art District; and (L-R) St+art co-founders Hanif Kureshi, Giulia Ambrogi, Arjun Bahl, and Thanish Thomas. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

Mattancherry, and will live beyond the Biennale.

Among them is a 200-metre mural by The Fearless Collective, which stretches along the Indian Coast Guard office. Ten artists turned the wall into a narrative of coastal life: with stories of fishermen, mangrove guardians and coastguards. Situating the street as the "middle ground" between polarised opinions, the Collective's founder artist Shilo Shiv Suleman emphasised the potential of public muraling "not necessarily as an act of adornment but as an act of public reclamation and transformation".

Space for everyone Suleman's words also loop into St+art's strategy across its many projects: banking on shared interests. For instance, they engage with local residents of the sites they work at. "We always conduct a recce to understand the people who live there," says the production manager. "We ask how we can engage with the community, if it has any local artists, what their stories are."

At Lodhi, this community work is most apparent in murals such as *Saath Saath*, created and painted by around 100 colony residents. Other works reflect the neighbourhood's people too, such as Mexico-based artist Paola Delfin's mural showcasing the women of the colony, and Gond artist Bajju Shyam's *Dilliwalie* (People of Delhi) with a dense crowd of foxes, "the cleverest creatures" in the jungle.

"Lodhi will continue to function as both origin point and testing ground," says chief curator and co-founder Giulia Ambrogi. Bahl adds: "We believe in getting things done. Getting out there and trying something, good or bad, and taking ownership of space that is for everyone."

The writer is an arts professional, offering an insider's view of the scene.

Deepthi Sasidharan

The Vijayanagara empire dominated the geopolitical landscape of the Deccan from the 14th to the 16th centuries before its destruction and abandonment. Vijayanagara, which means the City of Victory, continues into our times with the ruins at Hampi, now a World Heritage Site of immense cultural significance and newfound interest. The book *City of Victory: Hampi Vijayanagara* (Pictor), by archaeologists George Michell and John M. Fritz (with photography by John Gollings), is therefore not another architectural guidebook but a definitive visual and historical portrait of a city that was once the thriving capital of the most important Hindu kingdom in medieval South India.

The book is an updated presentation of the 1991 book by the authors. The older edition – with Michell's lifelong work on Deccani architecture and its dissemination, alongside Fritz's studies – was a landmark publication that brought early scholarly attention to Hampi. The new edition is designed for contemporary readers; Michell has reorganised the scholarship, updated the documentation work (that has continued since 1991), and published it in large format.

A few weeks ago, I had a chance to attend the photo exhibition that accompanied the book launch, at Bengaluru's Venkatappa Art Gallery. To my luck, architectural photographer Gollings was on site for a walkthrough of the



Hampi in light and stone

Updated book on City of Victory weaves historical narrative with architectural documentation

black-and-white photographs. Produced over 45 years, his lens captures buildings suspended in sweeping stone terrains, each shot a careful composition. One image was particularly arresting: the monumental 6.7-metre monolithic Lakshmi Narasimha at Hampi. Weathered, immense, and dignified even in ruin, it is among the most recognisable icons of Vijayanagara, commissioned by King

Krishnadevaraya in 1528. But something felt subtly unfamiliar. The deity, seated cross-legged in formidable calm, seemed familiar and yet altered. Gollings explained the shift. "In the 1980s, well-meaning conservators from the Archaeological Survey of India introduced a stone *yogapatta* – a supporting band across the knees – to stabilise the sculpture," he said. "In doing so, they

Garuda shrine at Vitthala temple; and (below) the carved columns at Tiruvengalanatha temple. (JOHN GOLLINGS)



inadvertently transformed the iconography." The original sculpture, once depicted with the goddess seated upon Narasimha's lap, had long lost its form. With the addition of the band, the image was reinterpreted as Yoga Narasimha, the ascetic manifestation we recognise today.

It was a quiet revelation. What centuries had weathered and neglect had sustained, restoration had subtly redefined.

An empire's timeline The text by Michell and Fritz reflects decades of documenting

Vijayanagara, and weaves historical narrative with architectural documentation and insight. Fritz is with us no more, but Michell spoke about his work at the launch, echoing the author's deep familiarity with the site. It was Fritz's idea, he said, to organise photographs into 'areas of interest' – landscapes, prestigious temples and so on. This shines through in the book as they establish the empire's timeline, delve into religious architecture and its central role in urban planning of the time, and guide the reader's journey through the city.

In its heyday, Hampi must have astounded visitors. Temples, palaces and market streets unfolded across a surreal boulder-strewn terrain. Sacred shrines lined the banks of the Tungabhadra, the region's life force. Massive granite blocks were carved into *mandapas* along the water, which could withstand seasonal flooding. Elsewhere,

rocks were cut into reservoirs serving temples located away from the river. Replete with explanations that expand historic spatial logic, and supplemented by maps, drawings and plans, the book is of use to the casual reader and the scholar.

Evocative journey The real treat, of course, is Gollings' photography. The Australian brings a rare sensitivity to the visual storytelling of Vijayanagara's ruins. His images capture the monumental scale of the site's granite landscape and the intricate details of its sculptural forms with dramatic light and shadow. He sometimes foregrounds the images with humans, or familiar plants or stones, enabling the viewer's discernment of scale, while elsewhere details are photographed as documentation, enabling study and reflection. The photos also span the medium from early analogue processes to large-format film and digital imaging, reflecting a consistent embrace of technological shifts without surrendering craft.

City of Victory stands out as one of the most compelling books on Vijayanagara available today. It balances narrative, analysis and visual beauty – and offers scholarly depth and an evocative journey through a city that may lie in ruins, but continues to live in stone, in memory and, through its pages, in light.

The writer is the founder-director of Eka Archiving Services.

